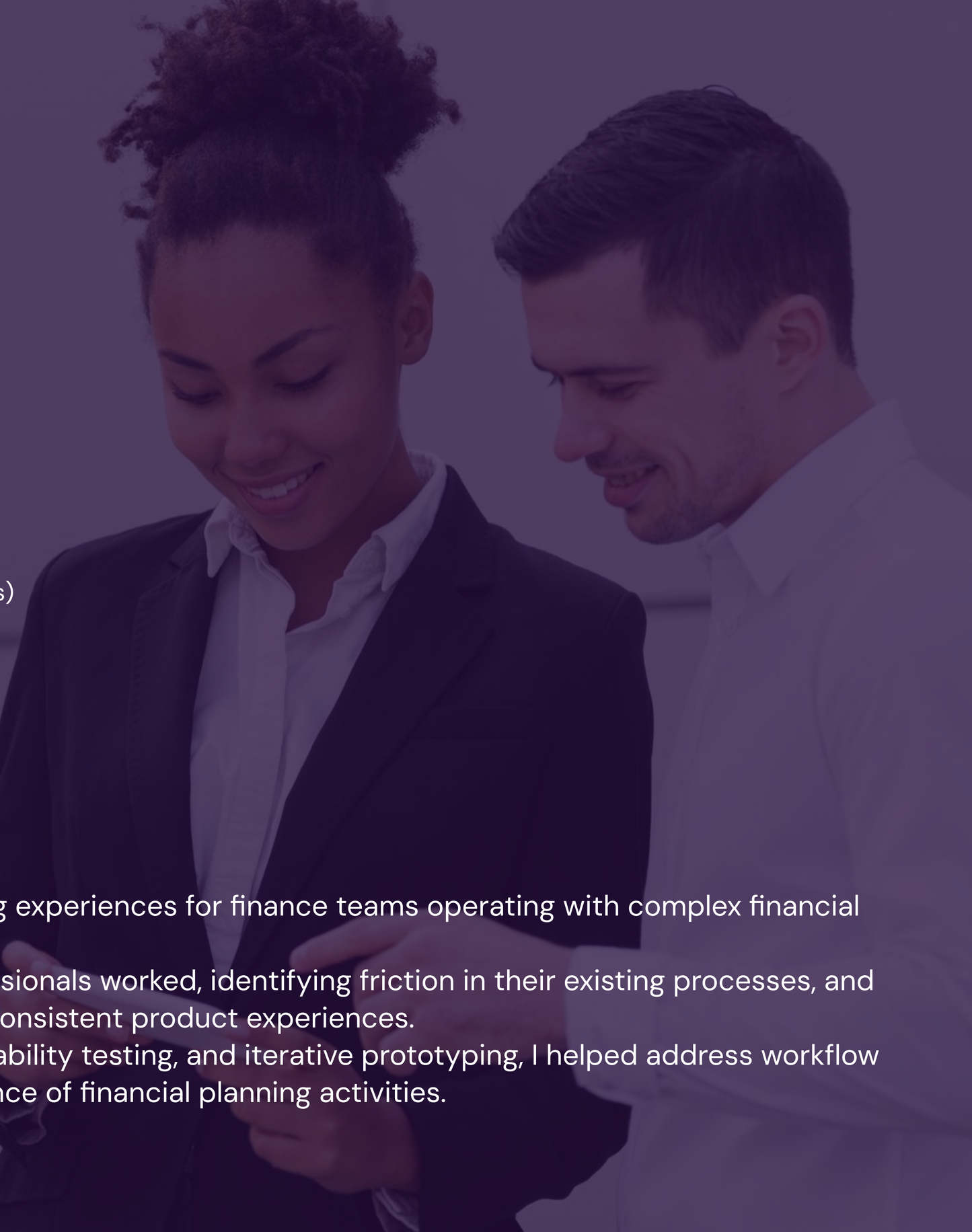
Phocas.

Budgeting & Forecasting

Role: Senior UX Designer

Environment: B2B SaaS (finance & operations teams)
Users: CFOs, Controllers, Operations Managers
Scope: UX Strategy · User Research · Workflow Design · Interaction Design · Design Systems
Team: Product Manager + Engineering Squad (7 Engineers)

Christchurch, New Zealand
Aug 2020 – Sep 2022



OVERVIEW

I worked on improving budgeting and forecasting experiences for finance teams operating with complex financial data and interconnected planning workflows.
My focus was understanding how finance professionals worked, identifying friction in their existing processes, and translating research findings into clearer, more consistent product experiences.
Through user interviews, ideation workshops, usability testing, and iterative prototyping, I helped address workflow complexity and improve the clarity and confidence of financial planning activities.

RESEARCH & PROBLEM DISCOVERY

Through user interviews, expert consultations, and workflow analysis, we identified recurring friction points that affected efficiency, consistency, and decision confidence.

01 — FRAGMENTED WORKFLOWS
Users frequently exported financial data into spreadsheets to complete planning activities, creating disconnected processes across tools.

02 — VERSION CONTROL CHALLENGES
Finance teams reported difficulties managing multiple versions of budgets and forecasts, making it harder to maintain a consistent view of financial information.

03 — HIGH COGNITIVE LOAD
Complex planning scenarios required users to interpret large amounts of financial data while navigating between different forecasting contexts.

04 — LIMITED WORKFLOW CONTINUITY
Moving between planning activities introduced friction and increased the effort required to maintain context throughout the forecasting process.

KEY RESEARCH INSIGHT
The challenge was not simply displaying financial information. It was helping finance professionals work with complex data while maintaining context, consistency, and confidence in their decisions.

CORE UX QUESTION
How might we simplify complex financial planning workflows while preserving the flexibility, accuracy, and control that finance professionals need?

UX STRATEGY & CONCEPT DEVELOPMENT

I used a structured UX process to translate research findings into design opportunities and explore potential solutions collaboratively.

01 — SYNTHESIZE RESEARCH FINDINGS
Analyze insights from finance professional interviews and expert consultations to identify recurring workflow problems, user needs, and opportunities for improvement.

02 — EXPLORE SOLUTIONS COLLABORATIVELY
Use ideation workshops to explore alternative approaches, challenge assumptions, and align product and engineering stakeholders around potential solutions.

03 — PRIORITIZE CLARITY AND CONTINUITY
Evaluate concepts against three principles:

- Context: Users should understand which forecasting mode they are working in.
- Continuity: Switching modes should not interrupt the planning workflow.
- Confidence: Users should be able to interpret and work with financial data without unnecessary uncertainty.

DESIGN SYSTEMS & PRODUCT CONSISTENCY

Beyond individual UX improvements, I contributed to establishing and validating design system principles through shipped product work and stakeholder alignment.
The objective was to create more consistent, reusable interaction patterns that could support the complexity and scale of the Phocas platform.

01 — STANDARDIZE COMPLEX DATA WORKFLOWS
Established consistent patterns for data tables and filters, helping create more predictable experiences across financial workflows.

02 — BUILD REUSABLE DESIGN PATTERNS
Developed scalable components and interaction patterns to support consistency and reduce duplicated design effort.

03 — VALIDATE THROUGH REAL PRODUCT WORK
Applied and refined design system principles through actual product delivery, using implementation and stakeholder feedback to validate their effectiveness.

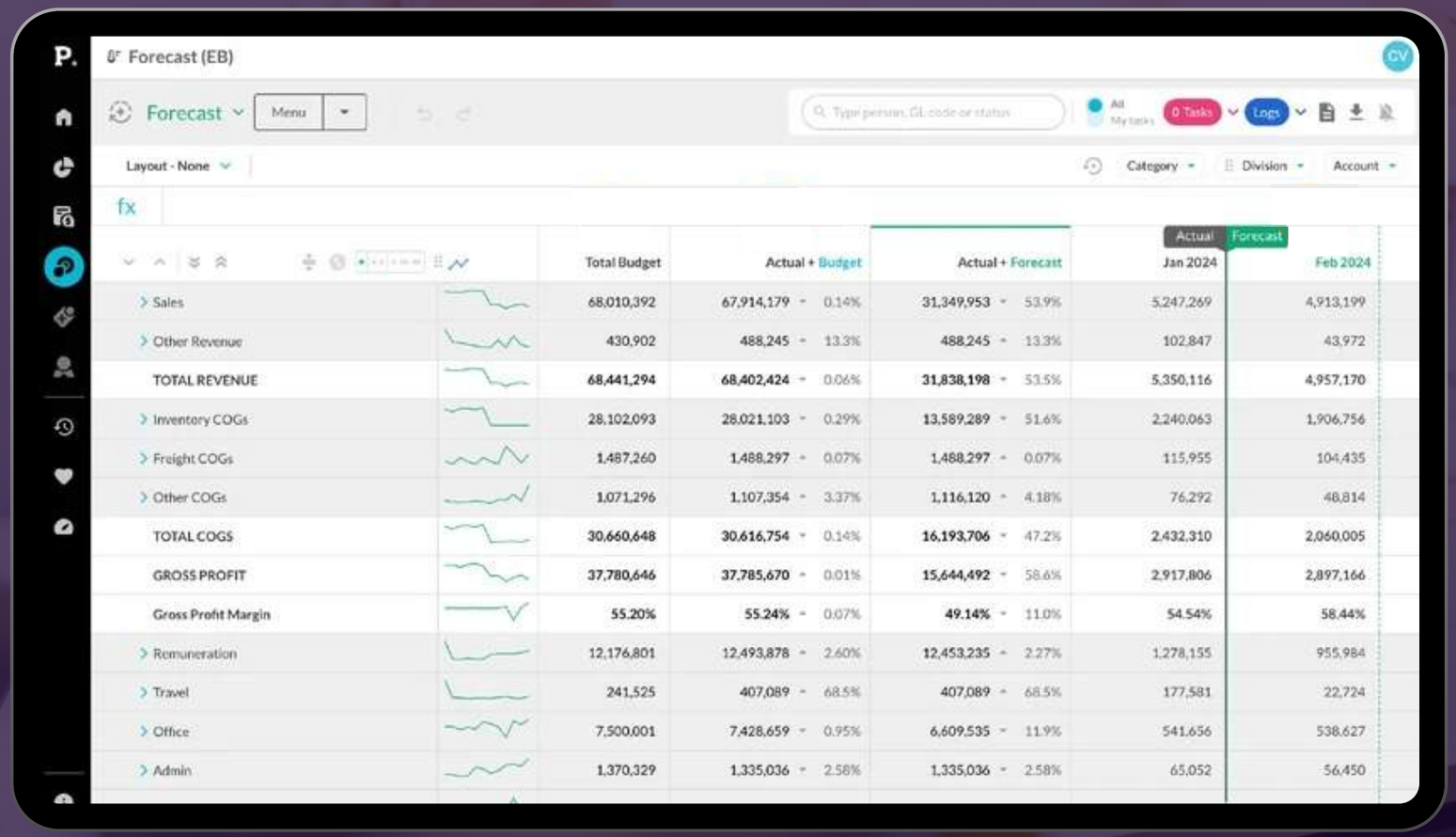
04 — PARTNER WITH ENGINEERING
Worked closely with the seven-engineer product squad to align design decisions with technical implementation and maintain consistency throughout delivery.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE
A design system should not exist only as a library of components. Its value comes from creating consistent, scalable experiences across the product.

KEY UX DESIGN CONTRIBUTION

Forecasting Switch ↔

I designed an interaction pattern that allowed users to move between forecasting modes without losing context or confidence.



RESEARCH & VALIDATION

I incorporated research and validation throughout the design process, using feedback to challenge assumptions, identify usability issues, and refine proposed solutions.

01 — USER INTERVIEWS
Engaged finance professionals to understand their workflows, challenges, expectations, and decision-making needs.

02 — EXPERT CONSULTATIONS
Gathered domain expertise to better understand financial planning requirements and evaluate proposed approaches.

03 — USABILITY TESTING
Evaluated product experiences with users to identify friction, assess interaction clarity, and understand where workflows created unnecessary complexity.

04 — ITERATIVE PROTOTYPE VALIDATION
Used prototype testing and user feedback to refine interaction patterns and improve the overall experience before implementation.

05 — COLLABORATIVE IDEATION
Facilitated workshops to explore alternative solutions, challenge assumptions, and align stakeholders around user-centered improvements.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE
Research should not be a one-time discovery phase. It should continuously inform, challenge, and validate product decisions.

BUSINESS IMPACT & REFLECTION

The evolution of Phocas' budgeting and forecasting capabilities contributed to a broader product offering, helping position the platform as an enterprise-grade business intelligence solution.

01 — MORE CONNECTED FINANCIAL WORKFLOWS

Integrated budgeting and forecasting capabilities supported a more cohesive financial planning experience.

02 — REDUCED MANUAL EFFORT

Workflow improvements and automation supported the broader goal of reducing manual reporting and operational overhead.

03 — ENTERPRISE PRODUCT EVOLUTION

The expansion of budgeting and forecasting capabilities contributed to Phocas' product evolution, enterprise positioning, and long-term commercial value.

04 — COMMERCIAL MILESTONE

Phocas was subsequently acquired by a US-based investment fund in a transaction valued at approximately $500 million, reflecting the platform's broader market position and commercial relevance.

KEY LEARNINGS

- Validation builds confidence: Iterative usability testing helps ensure that solutions address actual user needs.
- Consistency scales product quality: Design systems connect individual UX improvements into a coherent product experience.

FINAL REFLECTION

This project strengthened my approach to designing complex B2B products: understand the domain, involve users, challenge assumptions, validate decisions, and build scalable experiences that support better business decisions.